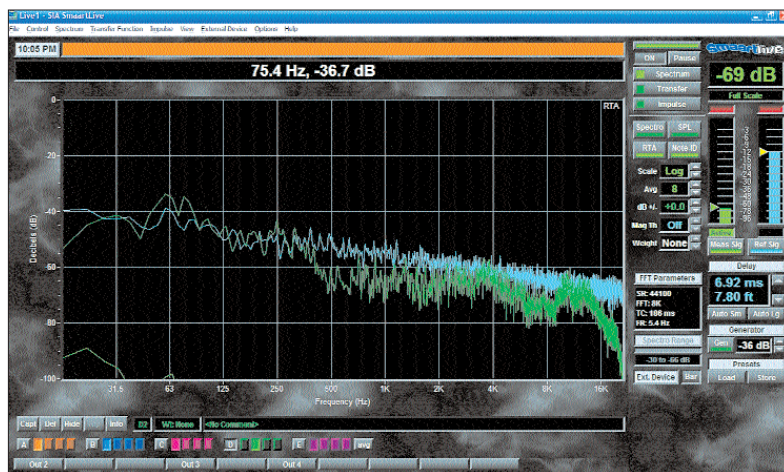




The Artis X10 Mini was by far the best sounding set, and analysis using SmartLive shows that it has only minor variations from the test signal—excellent for a multimedia set

class of its own. It could brilliantly create bullet sounds and explosion ricochets. We could go so far as to say that this set provides a better surround experience in gaming than any other.

Frequency tests

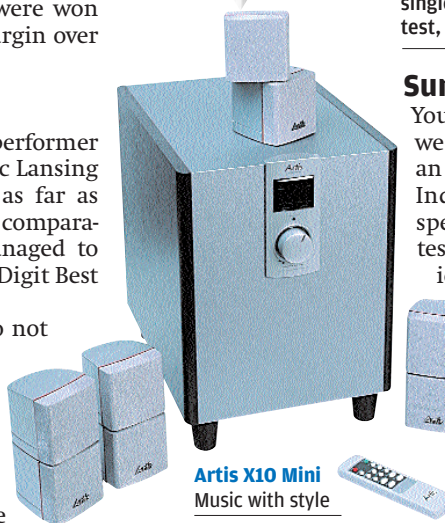
The Artis S6600R/FM ruled when it came to frequency tests. It performed exceedingly well in all the frequencies. The Zebronic ZEB-SW13100R produced harmonics in a few of the frequencies, and had to remain content with second place. While most of the brands were average performers in this test, the Creative exhibited dismal performance. The Altec Lansing VS3251 and the Tech-Com SSD-5101R missed the 250 Hz altogether. This was evident in the music test, where we found that these sets could not produce piano sounds in 2.1 mode.

The ultimate bass and treble tests were won by the ZEB-SW13100R by a narrow margin over the Artis S6600/FM.

And The Grammy Goes To...

The Logitech X-230 was the best performer amongst the 2.1 speaker sets. The Altec Lansing ATP3 was only a whisker behind it as far as sheer performance goes, but with its comparatively lower price of Rs 3,400, it managed to edge past the Logitech and secure the Digit Best Buy Gold in the 2.1 category.

The Altec Lansing FX4021 was also not far behind in the performance, in third place. But it is rich in features compared to the other sets. Not only does it sport stylish looks, it comes with wired as well as wireless remotes. It is also the only speaker set with dual woofers, and can be connected to the

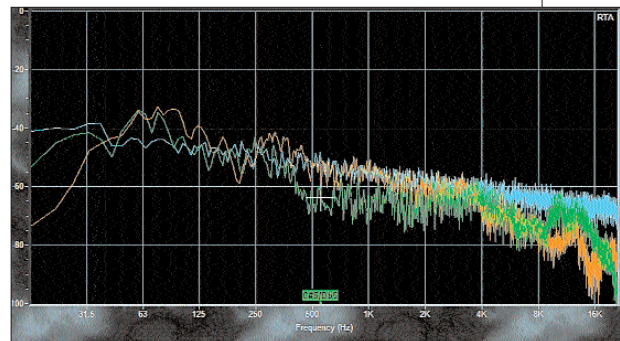


Artis X10 Mini
Music with style

USB port of a PC to listen to crystal-clear 5.1-channel audio. The Altec Lansing FX4021 is therefore the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver in the 2.1 category.

For the 5.1 speaker sets, the performance king was the Artis X10 Mini, closely followed by the Zebronic ZEB-SW13100R. While the ZEB-SW13100R was better at recreating a movie environment, the X10 Mini was better when audio fidelity was compared. In the end, the Artis X10 Mini, with its good looks and great music performance was adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold in the 5.1-channel category, despite being the most expensive at Rs 12,000.

The Artis S6600R/FM has almost everything that you need in a speaker set, and more. It is the only one amongst the 5.1 sets to have not only FM but also AM radio. In terms of performance, it came in third—not bad. The affordable price—Rs 8,500—leaves us with no option but to award the Artis S6600R/FM the Digit Best Buy Silver in the 5.1-channel category.



The Logitech Z5450 (green) and the Artis X10 Mini (orange) are quite similar in terms of reproducing bass, but the Artis have a slight edge when it comes to the highs. The Z5450 wasn't part of our test, but since only a single speaker and woofer is needed for the SmartLive test, we pitted it against the Winner

Summing It Up

You might have noticed that the test process we deployed was carefully devised to present an idea from the layman's point of view. Indeed, an audiophile would have tested speaker sets in a markedly different way. Such testing involves a studio and various electronic gadgets that can bring out the minutest of details in a speaker set, and over the entire audio frequency range. However, this is not the kind of environment where PC speakers are generally deployed, and therefore we chose a different path that helps us better identify with you, our readers.

That said, we decided to bring in an audiophile and have him take a look at some of the speakers that stood out in the tests. This review is peppered with his comments; this we did for those of you who want hard evidence and want to see frequency response graphs of some real audiophile tests.

Send feedback at readersletters@jasubhai.com if you want to see a more extensive audiophile test the next time we look at speakers! ■

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